

03. Work authorization and sponsorship

Twelve of the 43 postings ask something about your right to work. The wording decides what the correct answer is, and the wordings are not equivalent.

The wordings found in this sample

"Are you legally eligible to work for any employer in Canada?"

"Will you now or in the future require work visa sponsorship?"

"Will you need sponsorship for an employment visa?"

"If you currently hold an Open Work Permit, please provide the validity date (month and year) along with the date of issuance."

"Do you have a valid Canadian Passport OR B1B2 US Visa?"

"Are you legally authorized to work in the United States?"

Those are four different questions. The first is about eligibility today, the second and third are about future sponsorship, the open-permit one wants dates, and the last two are about travel to the United States. Answering "yes" to all of them, or "no" to all of them, produces at least one wrong answer.

What each answer actually is

- **Eligible to work in Canada, no sponsorship ever:** citizen, or permanent resident. The sponsorship questions are then a clear no, even though they are worded to sound like a trap.
- **Eligible now, sponsorship needed later:** a work permit with an end date. Eligible answers yes; the sponsorship question is also yes, and both are true at once. Say so before they find out, because the permit dates are in the application anyway.
- **Not eligible without sponsorship:** say it plainly and lead with the part that is in your control, which is the timeline and whether the role is on a pathway that supports it.
- **Post-graduate work permit:** name it as such. It is open, it has dates, and employers recognise it. Give the expiry.

Where the rule comes from: eligibility, permits and sponsorship are set by Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada, not by the employer or by this pack. If your situation is not one of the four above, read the IRCC page for your permit type before you answer, and if the stakes are high, get advice from a licensed immigration consultant or lawyer. This pack is not immigration advice.

What never helps

- Leaving it blank. In this sample these are required fields, so a blank is a lost application.
- Answering about your passport when the question asked about sponsorship.
- Overstating your status. It is discovered at the offer stage, after you have spent the time.